room in a steam ship. We really marvelled at the capacity of the cooks to be able to make food in such horrible conditions. We had meal halts and also technical halts for the engines to be changed or refuelled. Sometimes, we had unscheduled halts to allow higher priority trains to pass. At major stations we would get fresh rations and huge blocks of ice for cooling our compartments. Air conditioners were unknown in those days.

We had installed a 20-line field telephone exchange and telephones for key officers and the engine and the guard at the end of the train. Wherever we got an opportunity, we would go for a jog on the platform or the railway siding. The officer commanding of the train had entrusted me with the most thankless and enervating task of keeping a detailed record of all halts on this long journey. Therefore, I had to be on my toes 24x7 throughout the journey to maintain this log. I couldn't sleep peacefully either during the day or night. I had a few additional hands to help me in this task. Eventually, after many days, we reached Guwahati after crossing the mighty Brahmaputra over a very long bridge. This dual-purpose bridge had two decks, the lower one for the railway and the upper deck for the highway. The bridge was an engineering marvel and was reportedly constructed by Indian engineers. Though work on it started in 1958, the foundation stone was laid by Jawaharlal Nehru in January 1960 and it was commissioned in June 1963. Prior to that, the trains terminated at Amingaon on the north bank of the river. From there, the passengers and baggage were transferred into huge steam ferries and taken to the south bank, where there was a railway terminal at a place called Pandu, near Guwahati.

Facing the Naga Underground

From Guwahati to Dimapur in Nagaland, the railroad passed through thick tropical forests. We had heard of trains being stopped by the insurgents by felling trees across the track and by firing at the coaches. Therefore, we were ordered to be in combat gear with weapons at the ready, prepared for any eventuality! At times, when